
बातकि


EVERY CRAFT HAS A STORY

From Research Interest to Research Focus: The Journey Towards Bhairavgarh Batik.

During my time conversing with the Badwala family, who have practiced Batik for generations, I noticed a subtle loop/opportunity in their traditional workflow. This spark led us to experiment, innovate, and bring back a series of prototypes made purely with natural dyes



THE JOURNEY

The story in six parts

1
About Bhairavgarh
Place, river and the rise and fall of block print

Slides 4 to 7

2
The craftsmen
The Chhipa community and their knowledge

Slides 8 to 12

3
History of batik
From wax-resist origins to Bhairavgarh

Slides 13 to 16

4
How batik is made
Tools, process, techniques and colours

Slides 17 to 21

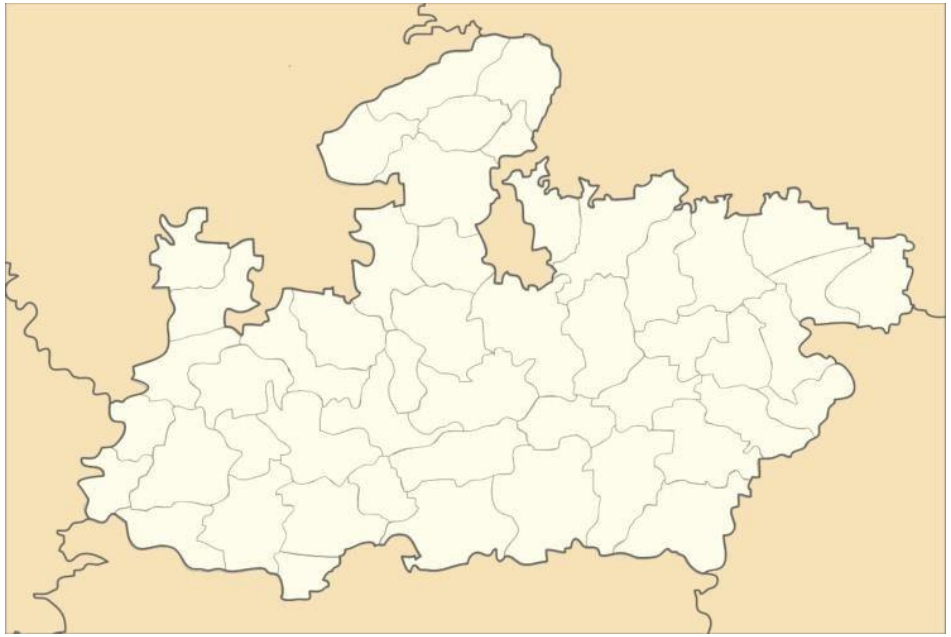
5
Reviving the craft
Natural dyes, Bhimbetka motifs, products, lab tests

Slides 22 to 28

6
The road ahead
Outcomes and sources

Slides 29 to 30

Madhya Pradesh: a state of printing rivers



Three hand-printing clusters, each tied to a river and a migrant artisan lineage.

Bhairavgarh, Ujjain

The state's main wax-resist batik centre

Bagh, Dhar

Direct block printing with madder and iron: deep red and black

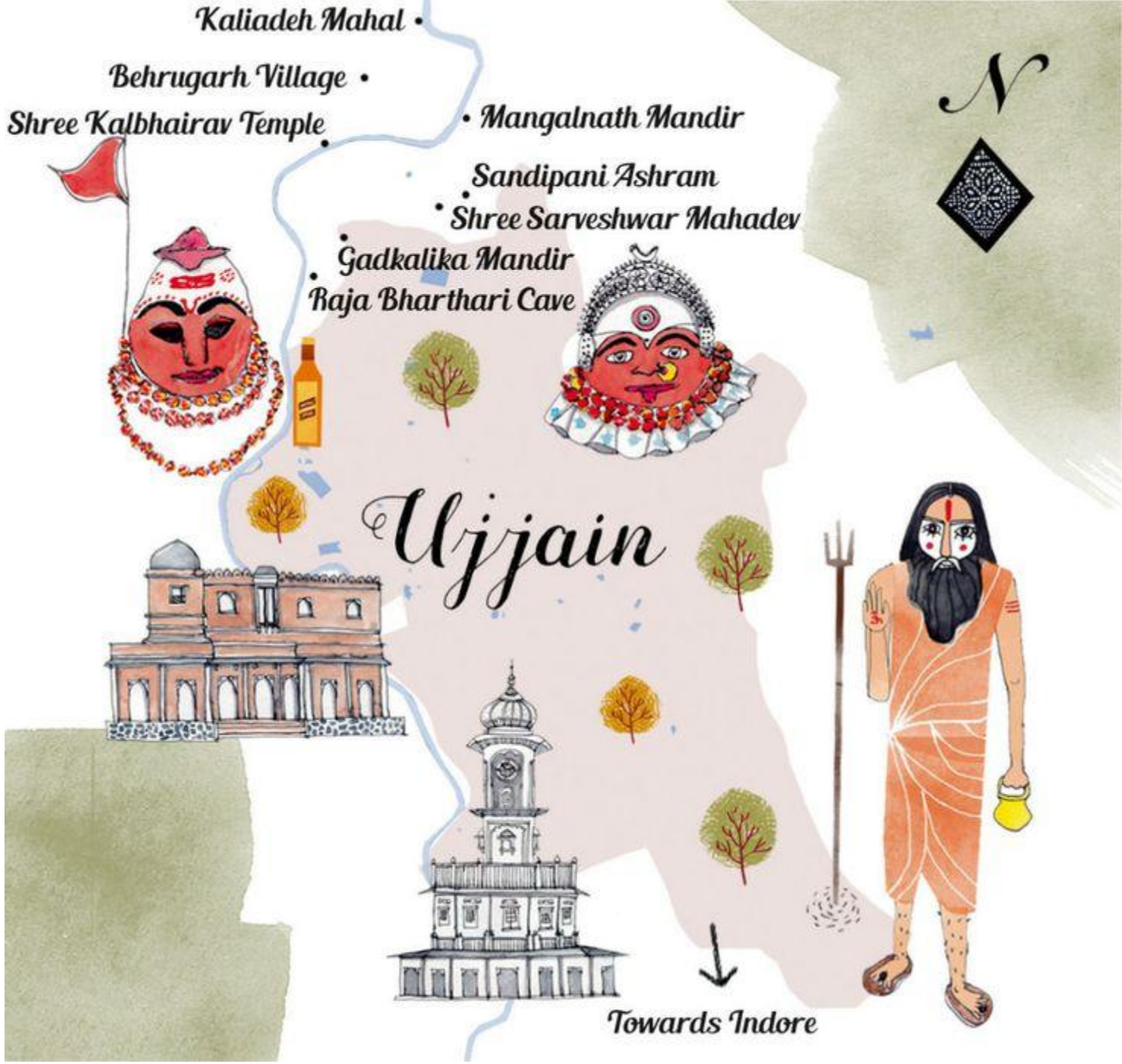
Jawad, Neemuch

Indigo-resist work with clay, gum and lime paste (Dabu)

Source: thesis Ch. 2, section 2.4. The Kshipra, Baghini and Jawad-area waters shaped where each craft settled.

About Ujjain

- Ujjain is there ligious capital of Madhya Pradesh and is one of the most famous city of the state. Situated in Malwa region near eastern bank of river Kshiprait's culture speaks volumes about Malwa and Nimar. It is famous for its Dal bafla and pohajalebi. With more than 1000 temples and one of the jyotirlingaa of Mahakal and famous kumbh melaheld after every 12 years it is one of the important pilgr image center of Hinduism.
- Bhairavgarh or Behrugarh isavillagesituated12kms from main city of Ujjain.It is named after Shree Kalbhairav temple who is said to be thear my chief of LordShiva. Bhairavgarhis also famous for its printed fabrics in all over country.



Bhairavgarh: a village on the Kshipra bank

- Story of Bhairavgarh is a classic example of downfall of a craft after industrialization. It is a very well known truth that when industry and millmade clothwasintroducedinIndia,theworstimpactwastakenbycraftclusters.Hand made clothing went out of fashion after 1950's and till now it is fighting to survive. Many craft clusters managed torega in their importance such as Chanderi andBaghbutmanyarestillstrugglingandsomehavelosttheirtrueidentity.One such case is a story of Bhairavgarh. "It is a classic case of a traditional printing are at hat went out in search of a modern market, was picked up by it for about 8 to 10 years and then completely dropped, for it could not compete in variety and price with the prints of Rajasthan and other silk screen prints" as quoted in book Saris of India.
- PrintersfromRajasthancamehereduringthereignofFerozshahTuglaqbecause of river Kshipra and the story of Bhairavgarh block prints started. The original designs and blocks had resemblance with Rajasthani designs since original printers belonged to Rajasthan. Traditional range of colours included Red from madderandalizarin, hirakasi black, indigo blue and non-fast colour that were madebymixingcolorwithbuttermilk.Allthesecametoendin1960's.

History of printers

- Originof printers ofMadhya Pradesh can be traced from RajasthanandGujarat. Printers fromRajasthanandGujarat migratedtoborderareasofMadhyaPradeshapprox.400years ago.Accordingtothepopularbelief(asgiveninbook“Sarisof India”),hinduprintersofRajasthangotconvertedtoIslam.This canbeconfirmedbythefact thatprintersanddyersofBagh and other places still has their surname as “Khatri” and “Cheepas” which are hindu community in Rajasthanwho belongstoNamdevsect. Printers used to practice dyeing with natural dyes which requiredlotofwaterandhencetheyhadtomovemoreoften insearchofrunningwaterwhichledtotheirestablishment in Baghnear riverBaghini,Ujjainnear riverKshipraandJawad nearNeemuch. It isbelieved that printers of Bagh learnt the techniqueof dyeing with alizarin and indigo from the artisans of Bhairavgarh.



Product range & motifs

- Fabricswereprintedaspertheirenduse.Someofthemwere lugda, bhairavgadi lugda, dhoti, burhani lugda, rehbari lugda, genda chunri, rajai khol, jaajam, safra/dastarkhan, palangposh/chaadar, jainamaz, jharia,kishangadicheent/chintz etc. Originally there were approx. 1500 original blocks of bhairavgarhprint. Out of theseonly 60—70blocks are left. Someof theblocksarebhairavgadi buta,burhani buta,dhoti buta, laggad,bela,gulli,narelia, chokhdi,dhoti ki kinar,kamal gatta, baadi bela, shahtoot,mandal, patashi, gaula, leheriya, aathiya, jawaariya, taakdaan, gaabla, khutri, chakri, phirma, chakri, kalashwaali chakri, aamdaal, peepal patta, haathi pagga, chunri border, phool chokhdi, kherala, keri, jaalwaali keri, jabdaar,chaand, janjeri,kangura,haathi, titli,ghoda,buti, bataana, safrekachaand,mehraab,minar, tota,moongphali, tiles,pharde,neempatti,haath-paan,paagdoandjhaaria. It is tobenoted thatblocksof animal andbirdswerequite popular even when all the printers belonged toMuslim community







What is batik? One of three resist families

TIED OR CLAMPED

Bandhani

The cloth itself is bound so dye cannot enter.

PASTE OR MUD

Ajrakh

Lime, gum and mordant paste controls how indigo and madder bond.

MOLTEN WAX

Batik

A hydrophobic wax barrier is applied hot and removed by heat.

Why it matters: wax is a physical barrier, not a chemical mordant. Natural dyes can therefore enter Bhairavgarh batik through dye and mordant chemistry alone, without changing the resist method.

Source: thesis Ch. 2, section 2.3 (after Hann, n.d.). The dye bath must stay cooler than the wax's melting point.

Batik travels the world

There is no single point of invention: wax-resist developed independently, or by early diffusion, in several ancient civilisations.

1

Java

The art form peaks. The canting, a copper pen, gives fine hand-drawn batik tulis; the cap, a copper stamp, makes it scalable (19th century).

2

Dutch trade

Colonial traders try to mechanise Javanese batik with engraved copper rollers and sell it back to Indonesia.

3

West Africa

The machine prints fail in Java but succeed in West African ports from the 1880s, and become Ankara or Dutch wax print.

4

UNESCO 2009

Indonesian batik is inscribed on the Representative List of Intangible Cultural Heritage: a whole motif vocabulary is protected.

Batik comes to India

1927

Rabindranath Tagore visits Java

Some craft sources trace resist-dyeing in India back about 2,000 years, and the debate on origins is still open.

Java to Santiniketan

Specimens, tools and knowledge of wax-resist return to Visva-Bharati.

Kala Bhavana

Artists adapt Javanese methods to Indian design vocabularies.

Regional clusters

Batik spreads to Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat and Rajasthan, and takes root at Bhairavgarh.

Batik in Bhairavgarh

Arrived with the printers

Families from Gujarat and Rajasthan carried batik along with block printing.

Grew when markets fell

From the 1940s to 1960s batik expanded as natural-dye and tin-chloride prints collapsed: it was quicker to learn and produce.

Reinvented by craftsmen

Master craftsman Rahim Gutti introduced kalamkari with a coconut-husk pen and the Indonesian tzanting.

Most
artisans do block batik

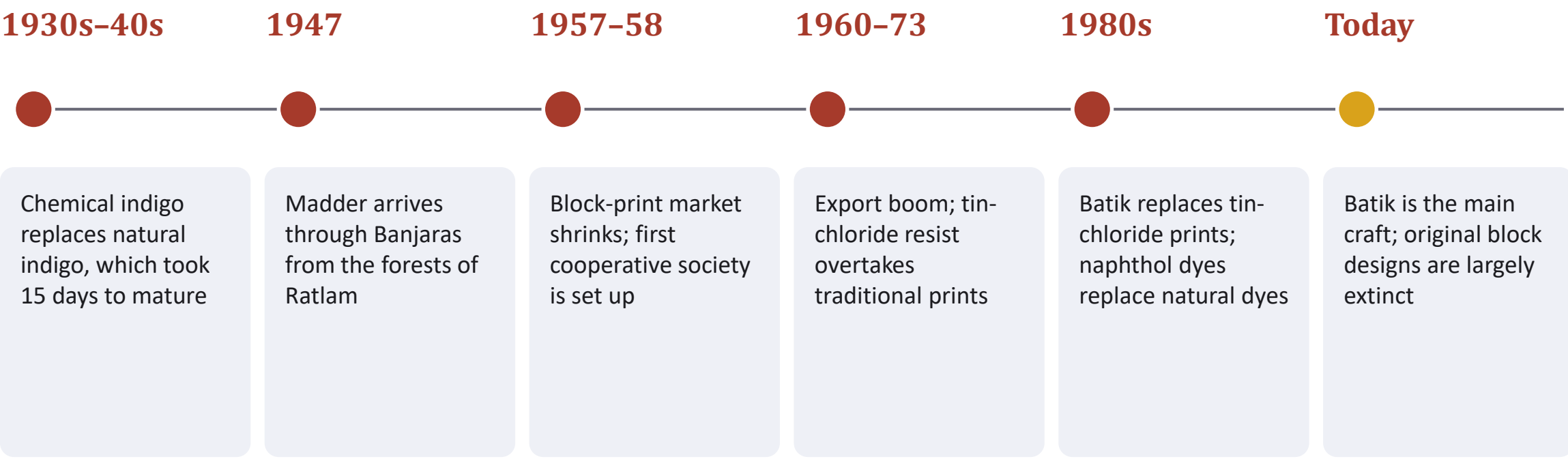
6–8
artisans do kalamkari

4–5
artisans do screen batik

2
work with tzanting

Techniques in use, as documented in 2019

Rise and fall of a block-print village



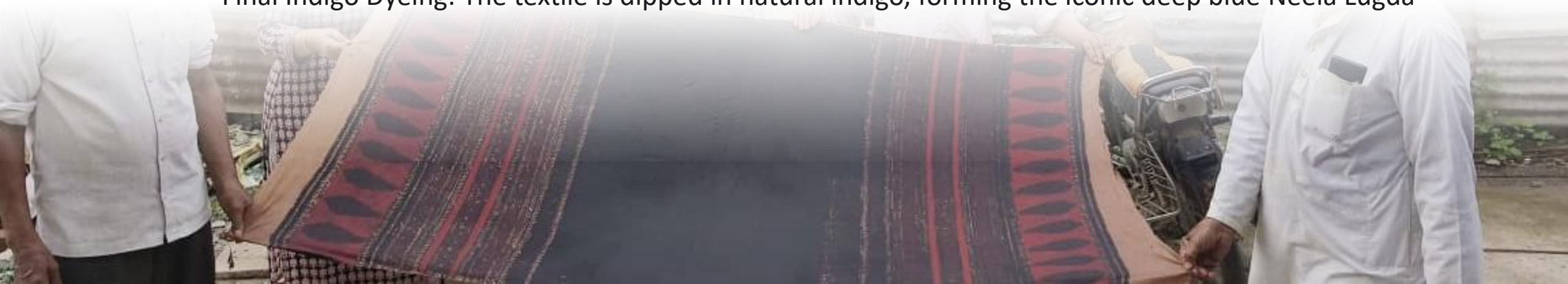
A classic case of a traditional printing area that went in search of a modern market, then could not compete in variety and price with Rajasthan and silk-screen prints.

Source: R. Nema (2019), Revival of Bhairavgarh block print; quoting 'Saris of India'. Dates are as recorded in that documentation.

Neela Lugda

- Worked directly with senior artisans in Bhairavgarh to understand traditional practices.
- Observed the emotional, cultural and personal value of the craft in daily life and memory.
- Recreated parts of the Neela Lugda process through hands-on participation and dialogue.
- Documented oral histories, craft lineage and lived experiences surrounding the textile.
- Built a collaborative revival model rooted in respect, reciprocity and shared authorship.

- **Traditional Process Documentation**
  - Fabric Preparation: Cotton cloth is washed and treated with harda to prepare it for natural dyes.
  - Block Printing with Mordants: Wooden blocks apply alum (red) and ferrous sulphate (black) patterns.
  - Curing (Padat Rakhna): Fabric rests for 7–8 days to allow absorption and color development.
  - Alizarin Dyeing: Cloth is simmered with Dhawde flowers to reveal warm red and deep black tones.
  - Gar Resist Application: A paste of yellow clay and gum resin creates resist patterns for layout.
  - Final Indigo Dyeing: The textile is dipped in natural indigo, forming the iconic deep blue Neela Lugda



Neela Lugda

- **Problem Statement**
  - The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.
  - Fast fashion has commodified its motifs, separating them from their cultural meaning.
  - The original natural dyeing and block-printing knowledge survives only with a few elderly artisans.
  - Loss of traditional wooden blocks and community-specific motifs threatens cultural continuity.
  - Chemical dye practices have replaced sustainable methods, affecting health and the environment.
  - Without urgent revival and documentation, the cultural narrative woven into the Neela Lugda may be lost forever.

- **Why Revival is Important**
  - The Neela Lugda carries the memories, identity and social history of the communities who wore it.
  - Revival strengthens the dignity and recognition of the artisans who have preserved this knowledge.
  - Restoring natural dye practices promotes ecological balance and healthier working environments.
  - Reconnecting motifs to their meanings prevents the cultural narrative from being diluted or erased.
  - Revival supports sustainable livelihoods while honoring craft lineage and ancestral knowledge

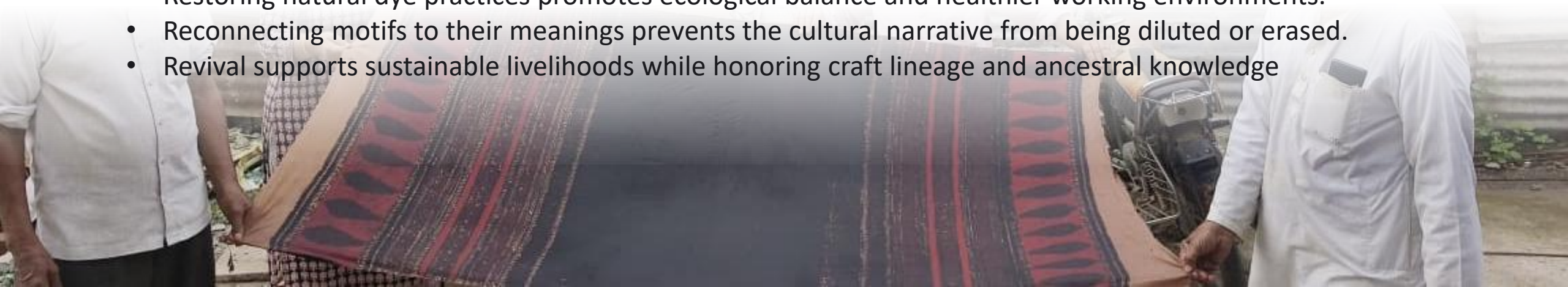


Table runner and bedsheets

- The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.
- Fast fashion has commodified its motifs, separating them from their cultural meaning.
- The original natural dyeing and block-printing knowledge survives only with a few elderly artisans.
- Loss of traditional wooden blocks and community-specific motifs threatens cultural continuity.
- Chemical dye practices have replaced sustainable methods, affecting health and the environment.
- Without urgent revival and documentation, the cultural narrative woven into the Neela Lugda may be lost forever.





Kaftan

- The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.





Men's jacket

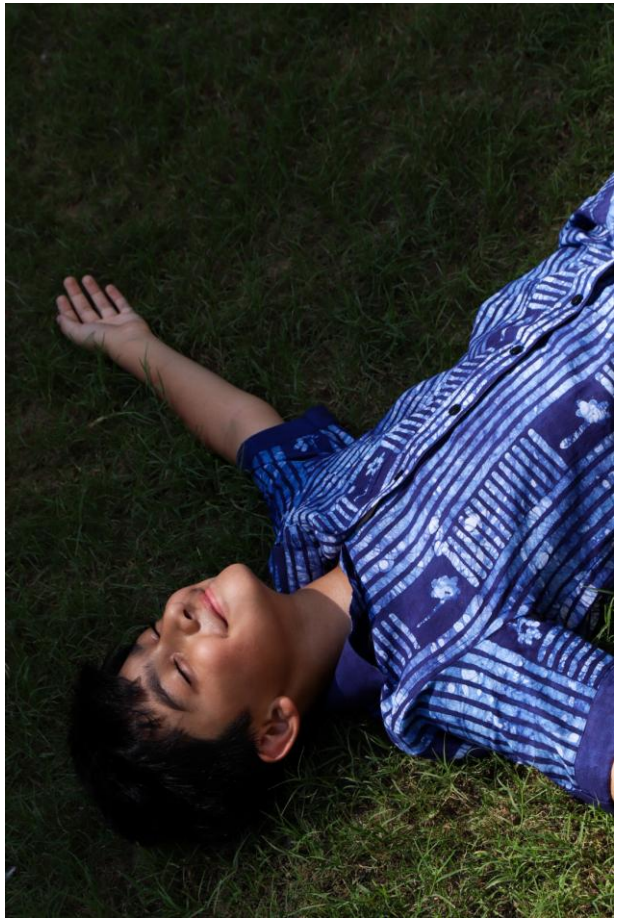
- The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.
- Fast fashion has commodified its motifs, separating them from their cultural meaning.





Men’s and Kid’s shirt

- The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.
- Fast fashion has commodified its motifs, separating them from their cultural meaning





Diary cover

- The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.
- Fast fashion has commodified its motifs, separating them from their cultural meaning.



File cover

- The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.
- Fast fashion has commodified its motifs, separating them from their cultural meaning.



Saree

- The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.
- Fast fashion has commodified its motifs, separating them from their cultural meaning.



Goggle cover

- The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.
- Fast fashion has commodified its motifs, separating them from their cultural meaning.



Pillow cover

- The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.
- Fast fashion has commodified its motifs, separating them from their cultural meaning.



Canvas tote bag

- The Neela Lugda, once a symbol of identity and memory, is now disappearing.
- Fast fashion has commodified its motifs, separating them from their cultural meaning.



The Chhipa: people who print

~400

years since Chhipa families reached Bhairavgarh, in the Mughal era, from Gujarat and Rajasthan

Other accounts place the arrival earlier, under Firoz Shah Tughlaq.



A hereditary caste

Dyers, tailors and block-printers, also written Chippa or Chimba.



A name that means the work

From the Hindi verb chhapna, 'to print'.



Skills held by the family

Preparing cloth, printing, dyeing, motif making and finishing are learnt by doing, parent to child.

Following the water

Natural dyeing needs large amounts of flowing water, so printing families kept moving until they found a river to settle beside.

Bhairavgarh printers took part in the revival of Bagh print, and Bagh printers are said to have learnt alizarin and indigo dyeing from Bhairavgarh.



Source: thesis Ch. 1 and 2; R. Nema (2019). The Bagh learning account is a popular belief recorded there.

A cloth for every community

Anjana
Neela lugda

Bagri
Lal lugda

Gaari
Kala lugda

Mali
Makhi bhant lugda

Bhil
Bootidar lugda

Gujar
Chunadi

Rajput
Bandhav chunri

Brahman and Baniya
Bhairavgarhi dhoti

Each community wore its own printed cloth for religious and community occasions.

Source: R. Nema (2019). Coloured chips mark cloths named for a colour; grey chips are not colour claims.

Knowledge held in the hands

Wax lines are drawn freehand, from memory, with no sketch or guideline. Floral and creeper motifs pass from one generation to the next by watching and doing.

16

artisans took part in two workshops

8 + 8

at Bhairavgarh and at Bagh



Thesis Fig. 4.1: the Bhairavgarh workshop, where fieldwork was observed

When tacit knowledge is not recorded, it can fade as materials, methods and markets change. Documenting it is part of the research.

From 1,500 blocks to 60

1,500
original blocks once existed

60–70
are left today

Surviving block names

Bhairavgarhi buta, burhani buta, dhoti buta, kamal gatta, mehraab, minar, peepal patta, haathi, titli, ghoda, tota, neem patti.

Animal and bird blocks stayed popular even among Muslim printers.



Source: R. Nema (2019). Photo: block store at Bhairavgarh, thesis Fig. 4.1.

Tools and materials



Coconut-husk stylus

Husk bound to a metal rod or capillary; wax flows by capillary action.

Sand-covered table

A damp 1 to 2 cm layer of sand stops wax sticking to the table.

Wax blend

Paraffin, mixed 70:30 with beeswax for blocks; paraffin alone for pens, since beeswax blocks the capillary.

Fabric

Cotton or silk, including Chanderi and Maheshwar weaves.

Source: R. Nema (2019) for the cluster's wax practice; thesis Ch. 2 for the stylus. Textbooks cite a 75:25 paraffin-beeswax blend (55–60.5 °C).

How a batik cloth is made

1 Pre-treat

Wash the cloth to remove dust, size and impurities, then dry.

2 Wax

Apply molten wax where the cloth must stay undyed.

3 Dye

Immerse or paint the cloth; waxed areas resist the colour.

4 Repeat

Re-wax and overdye for each extra colour the design needs.

5 Dewax

Remove the wax in boiling water to reveal the pattern.

6 Wash and dry

Rinse until the water runs clear, then dry.

Five ways to apply the wax

Block batik

A carved block is dipped in wax and stamped on the sand table. The easiest and commonest method.

Kalamkari pen

Coconut husk, yarn or hair wound on a metal capillary draws finer lines than a block.

Brush batik

For large areas; the cloth is stretched on a frame with hooks to avoid error marks.

Sponge batik

A makeshift stamp cut from a sponge when the right block is not available.

Tzanting

The most laborious and finest technique, with a PVC-and-nozzle pen devised locally.

Tools are improvised from local materials: coconut husk, yarn, PVC pipe and sponge.

Colours: then and now

Then: natural

Mordant and iron-acetate printing

Madder red

Iron black

Indigo blue

Now: synthetic

Chemical dye systems in batik

Naphthol

Indigosol

Reactive

Vat



Thesis Fig. 4.1: dye room and wash tank, Bhairavgarh. Swatches are illustrative.

Where the craft stands today

Generic branding

Bhairavgarh batik is hard to tell apart from other batik centres.

Fading knowledge

Skills learnt by doing are at risk when materials and demand change.

Chemical dye dependence

Synthetic dyes dominate, beside a river whose pollution is documented.

Market pressure

Competition, costs and low recognition squeeze artisan livelihoods.

Lost design language

Original block designs are largely extinct and styles lack uniformity.

The balance

Revival must hold tradition, sustainability, innovation and market together.

A revival, not a replica

Document

Record the Chhipa community's techniques, tools and experience.

Natural dyes

Test madder, indigo, marigold, catechu and more for batik.

Bhimbetka motifs

Turn rock-art forms into a Bhairavgarh design vocabulary.

Artisan partners

Treat artisans as active makers of the revival.

Market fit

Assess demand, branding and contemporary products.

Revival here means linking traditional knowledge with suitable present-day interventions, not restoring an old technique unchanged.

Bhimbetka: a design source from the rock



Thesis Fig. 1.6: rock paintings of Bhimbetka

2003

UNESCO World Heritage listing

MP

same state as Bhairavgarh

The shelters hold human figures, animals, hunting scenes and group activity. The study does not copy them: it analyses selected forms and adapts them into motifs that suit wax and block.

From rock wall to wax block

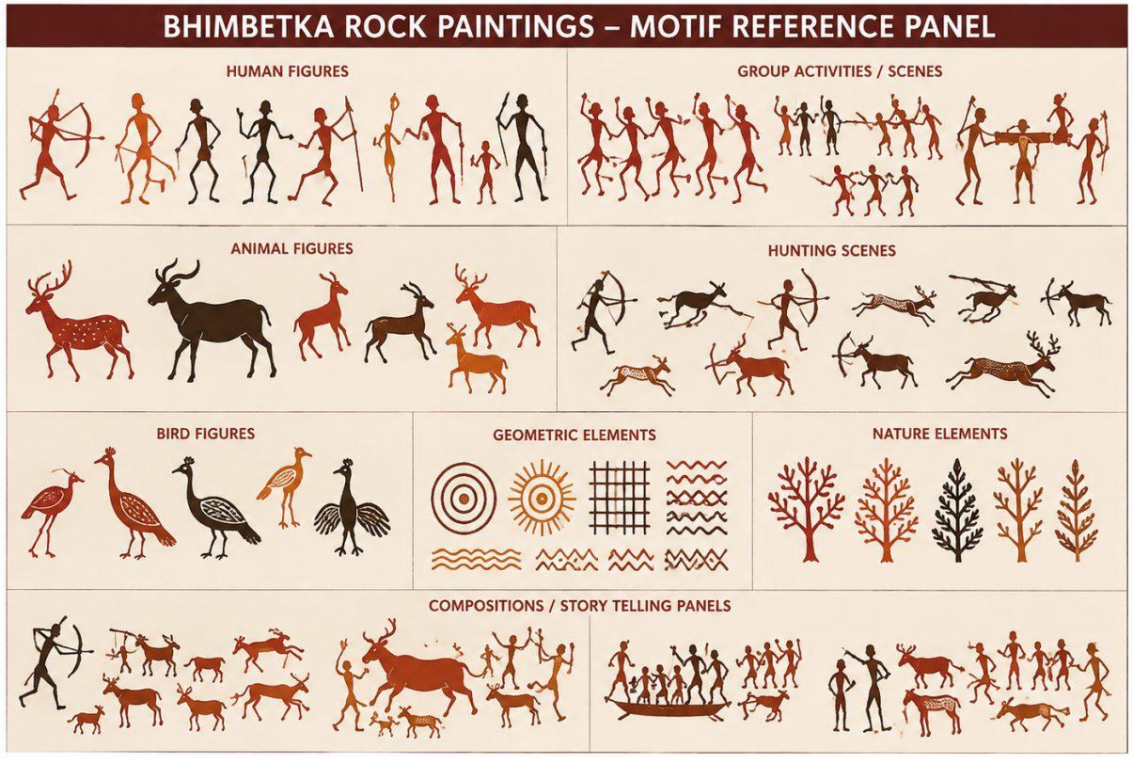


Figure 1.7: Selected Visual Elements from Bhimbetka Rock Paintings for Motif Development

A motif reference panel showing human figures, animals, group activities, geometric and nature elements from Bhimbetka rock paintings, providing inspiration for textile design development.

1

Deconstruct

Study line quality, geometry and negative space.

2

Stylise

Simplify for molten wax, wooden blocks and a hand stylus.

3

Prototype

Test on handloom cotton with the Chhipa artisans.

4

Validate

Review with artisans and independent design specialists.

Ritual or spiritual motifs stay out of commercial use.

The natural dye palette



Madder (Manjistha)
Crimson, brick red

Marigold
Mustard, ochre

Indigo
Cobalt to navy

Babool bark
Earthy brown

Pomegranate peel
Olive, khaki

Catechu (cutch)
Chocolate brown

Henna leaf
Olive brown, bronze

Alkanet root
Ruby, lavender

Turmeric
Yellow

Iron + jaggery
Charcoal, slate

Source: thesis Ch. 4, Table 4.2. Swatch colours are illustrative; see product photos for actual shades.

The natural dyeing sequence

1 Desize

Soak unbleached cotton in soapnut (aritha) water, 24 to 48 hours.

2 Mordant

50 g alum in 7 L water at 60 °C for 30 minutes; sun-dry.

3 Print wax

Block-print the design in wax on the dry cloth.

4 Dye

Immerse in the plant bath; indigo takes 2 to 3 dips with air oxidation.

5 Set

Shade-dry 24 hours, then a 10-minute mild alum or iron bath.

6 Dewax and wash

Boiling water for wax; cool wash with pH-neutral soap; dry in shade.

About 22 litres of water per colour cycle: 7 L mordant bath + 15 L dye bath, before rinsing.

Ten products, ten natural colours



Home furnishing, apparel and accessories



File cover: pomegranate peel



Pillow cover: alkanet root



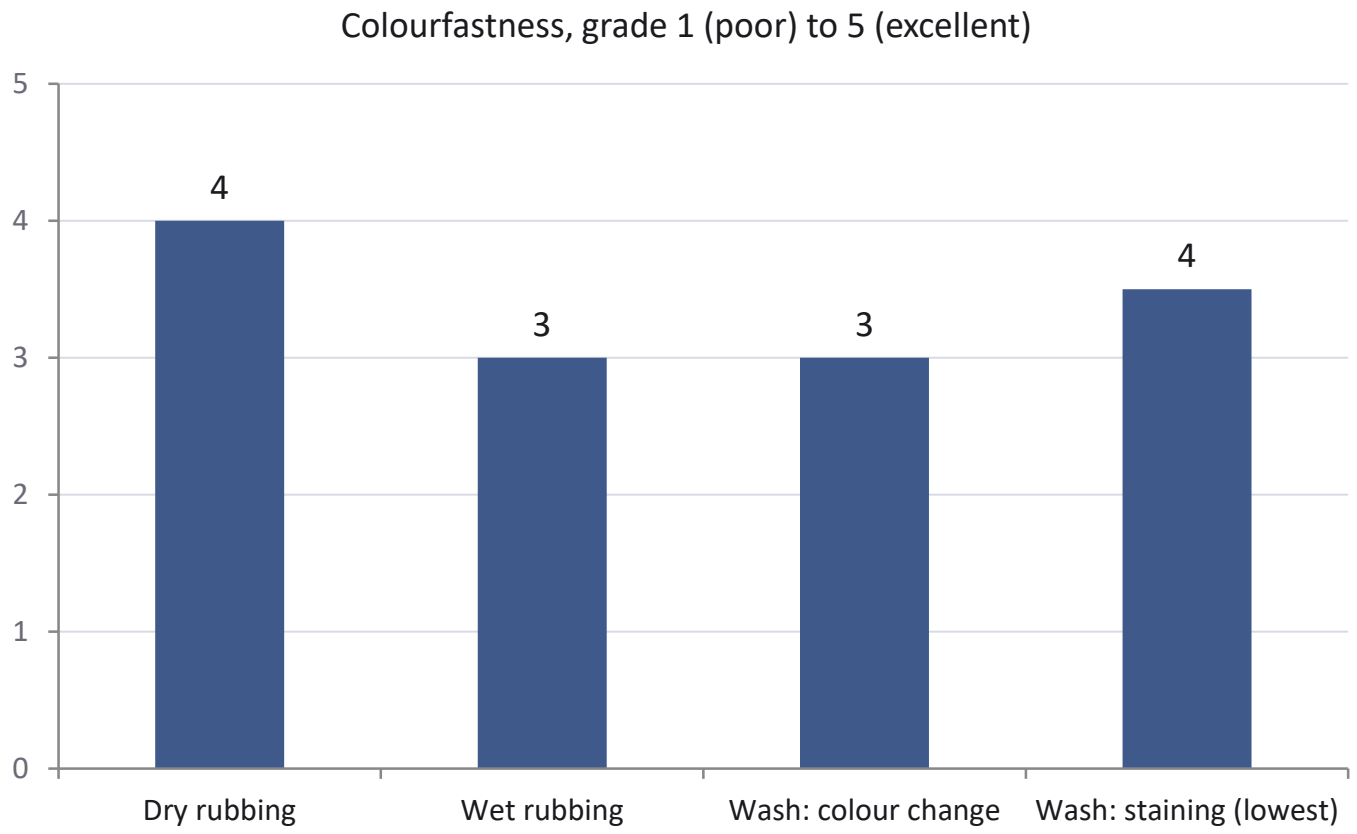
Tote bag: turmeric



Saree: catechu

Also: table runner and bedsheets (iron liquor), kaftan (madder), jacket (marigold), shirt (indigo), goggle cover (henna). Thesis Ch. 4.

What the laboratory says



No colour change

Spot extraction test is consistent with natural dye.

4 of 8

Light fastness on the blue wool scale.

Moderate to good

Care: cool hand wash, dry in shade.

The lab gave one combined grade for all ten samples, so dyes and mordants cannot yet be compared one by one.

Source: SSM Tex Lab, Ahmedabad, Test ID SAR 26-27-610 (29 Sept 2026); thesis Table 4.6. Effluent tests (pH, TDS, COD) are still to be reported.

The road ahead

1. Document the Chhipa community's knowledge before it fades.
2. Bring back natural dyes, tested for fastness and effluent.
3. Build a Bhimbetka motif language for a Bhairavgarh identity.
4. Keep artisans at the centre of every decision.
5. Test the market: branding, policy and contemporary products.

Every craft has a story. This one is still being written.



SOURCES

References and links

Used for this deck

R. Joshi, doctoral thesis: Synopsis and Chapters 1 to 5 (revised drafts).

R. Nema (2019), Revival of Bhairavgarh block print and technique development in batik, graduation project, NIFT Bhopal (reference PDF).

Behance: Craft Documentation, Batik of Bherugargh

Photographs: thesis fieldwork records and figures (Chapters 1 and 4).

Cited in the thesis

- Roy Maulik (2021): Tagore, Java and Indian batik
- Santiago, Cunha and Cabral (2023): natural dyes review
- Li et al. (2020) and Febriani et al. (2023): batik origins
- UNESCO ICH (2009): Indonesian batik
- UNESCO World Heritage Centre (2003): Bhimbetka
- Gaatha (n.d.); Handicrafts.nic.in (n.d.): Bhairavgarh tools
- Hann (n.d.): resist-dyeing families